CUSTOM GPT PROJECT BUSINESS CASE

MSIN0179: Project Management for Engineers

In collaboration with Regenerative Consulting (ReCon)

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Executive Summary

Coca-Cola is looking to use AI to transform its business from linear to a more circular, regenerative, and distributive model. Coca-Cola will benefit from this transition as it aims to improve the company's sustainability strategies, create social and customer value, regenerate natural systems, eliminate waste through circular design and solidify its position as a leader in the beverage industry.

ReCon is a boutique consultancy firm which aims to support this kind of organizational development. ReCon has previous experience in custom GPT projects (e.g. Nike) and would benefit from this business case to become a leader in AI-enabled sustainable business transformation.

The project will be implemented using an **Extended Life Cycle** (APM, 2019), completed in 5 stages – from a concept phase to a benefits realizations phase. The project is estimated to last **41 weeks**, starting December 13, 2024, and to cost **£3,408,850**.

The **objectives** for the GPT are to **promote sustainable product design**, **equitable labor practices**, **circular economy integration, customer engagement and transparency, innovation, and financial and environmental benefits**.

Success will be measured by achieving these goals within the defined budget and timeline, while maximizing stakeholder satisfaction and enhancing Coca-Cola's reputation.

Section 1: Strategic

1.1 Background

Founded by pharmacist Dr. John Stith Pemberton on May 8, 1886, in Atlanta, Georgia, Coca-Cola is now the world's most famous soft drink company (Anon., 2024). As of 2013, Coca-Cola's products have been sold in over 200 countries worldwide, with more than 2 billion beverage servings being sold each day (Coca-Cola, 2024). As of 2023, Coca-Cola was ranked the world's number one plastic polluter. Reports showed that the company's labels were found on 33,820 pieces of plastic waste across 40 countries, more than the next two top polluters combined (Plastic, 2024). This highlights the urgent need for the company to shift from its traditional predominant linear model to a more distributive, regenerative and circular business model.

1.2 Situation Analysis

Coca-Cola's sustainability can be evaluated using the following SWOT.

	Helpful	Harmful
Internal	**STRENGTHS** **1.** Water security improvements: Returned 148% of water used in finished beverages to nature, accounting for a cumulative 861 billion liters of water between 2021 and 2023 **2.** Circular economy for packaging design: in 2023, 90% of packing recyclable was recyclable. 62% was collected for recycling in 2023 **3.** Efforts towards climate change impacts: 8% decline in GHG emissions since 2015 (Company, 2023) **4.** Boosted employability of youth to 944,948 individuals since 2017 (HBC, 2023) Strong brand identity and global presence	**WEAKNESSES** **1.** Pollution: 5.62 million metric tons of GHG emissions due to manufacturing (Tiseo, 2024). In 2022, Coca-Cola's declared producing 3 million tons of plastic packaging a year (Chapter, 2022) **2.** Lawsuits: in 2020, Earth Island claimed Coca-Cola is greenwashing/falsifying their sustainability efforts (Law, 2024). **3.** Beverage contents: claims that drinks contain high toxic PFAS levels (Perkins, 2023) **4.** Heavy reliance on bottling partners.
External	**OPPORTUNITIES** **1.** Be more environmental-friendly: reduce GHG emissions (scope 1,2, and 3) emissions by 30% by 2030, reach net zero by 2040. Ensure all markets operate on 100% renewable electricity by 2030. **2.** Innovative packaging: Make 100% of their primary packaging recyclable by 2025. Stop oil-based virgin plastic usage by 2030 **3.** Efficient supply-chain: Ensure 100% of main agriculture ingredients/raw materials are sourced sustainably **4.** Better consumer-health: Reduce sugar content and aim for 50% of sales to come from low and no-calorie drinks by 2025 in Europe	**THREATS** **1.** Competitors (PepsiCo, Nestlé) have lower levels of pollution and appear as more environmental-friendly **2.** Missing sustainability targets discredited the company's efforts. **3.** Large global presence makes Coca-Cola's sustainability efforts vary for different countries. **4.** High cost of material/bottle redesign (Clancy, 2024)

Table 1. Sustainability SWOT Analysis

1.3 Weakness Areas

Though Coca-Cola has several weaknesses, it's most prominent issue revolves around pollution. The table below, extracted from the journal The National (Dutta, 2022), shows pollution has constantly increased since 2018. This caused Coca-Cola to face many lawsuits: Los Angeles County sued the company in 2024 for polluting the US's most populated county with plastic bottles, lying about the recyclability of their packaging, and lacking transparency on their impact on the environment (Raymond, 2024). These issues directly go against Coca-Cola's objectives (*elaborated in the Executive Summary*).

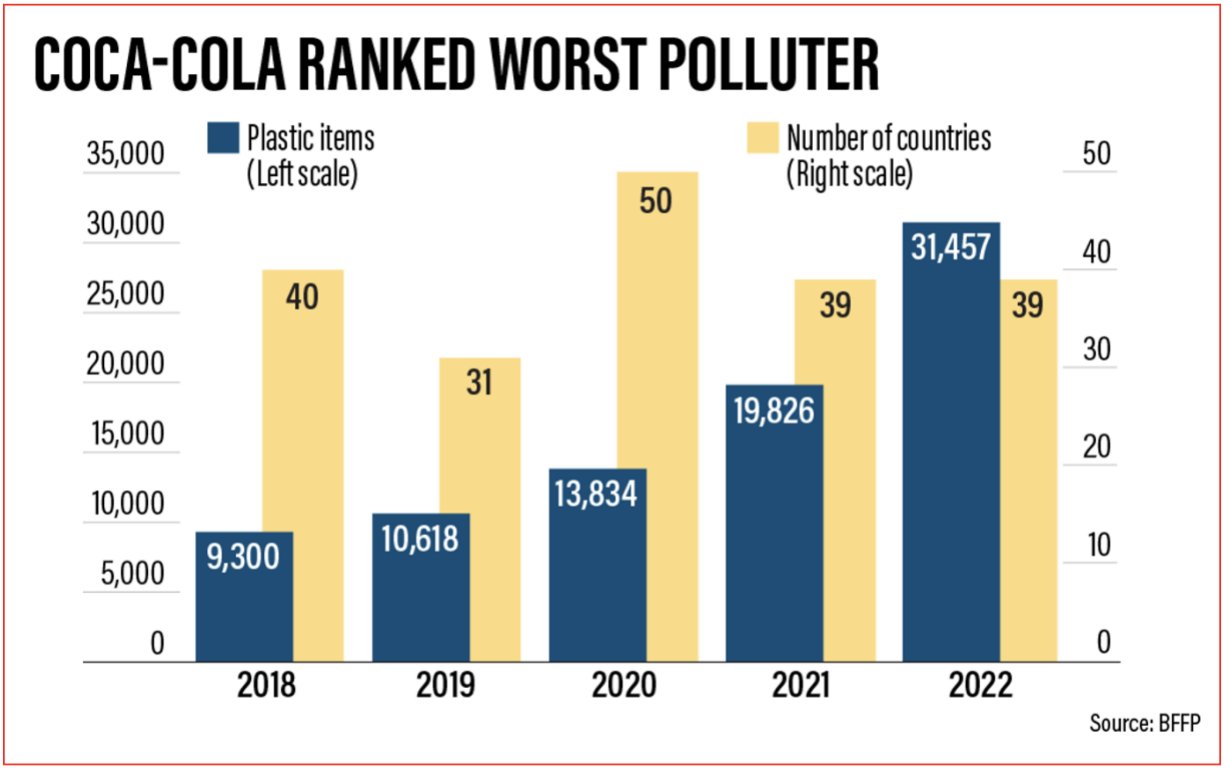

Figure 1. Coca-Cola plastic pollution histogram

Section 2: Options Appraisal

2.1 Solutions Considered

ReCon is committed to provide solutions that will aid the business in shifting to a sustainable business model. This requires evaluating options against agreed benefits, criteria, and objectives while avoiding decision bias, using an optioneering approach that considers technical, social, procurement, management, and transition-related aspects tailored to sustainability (APM, 2019).

Option 1: Do nothing.

Maintaining the current business model and strategies, potentially overlooking its sustainability weaknesses.

Option 2: GPT with Transition to Fully Recyclable/Biodegradable Packaging Feature

Diversifying bottling partners and/or aiding them to find affordable biodegradable materials for packaging, through researching alternatives to plastic bottles, such as bioplastics (Adetunji, 2023), promoting a circular economy.

Option 3: GPT with Optimizing Supply Chain Feature

Managing waste efficiently during the manufacturing process of the products. Finding geographical locations which can accommodate for renewable energy amenities to power the manufacturing sites and reduce GHG emissions.

Option 4: GPT with Programs for Diversity and Inclusion Feature

Implementing recruitment quotas and develop programs to promote diversity and inclusion within the workforce.

2.2 Selection Criteria

The options are evaluated on a scale from 1, least feasible, to 5, most feasible, and weighted according to their relevance to sustainability (1 not important, 5 very important). (ProjectManager, 2024). The criteria were formulated based on the Coca-Cola's sustainability objectives discussed in the *Executive Summary*.

		1		2		3		4	
Criteria	**Weighted Rating**	**Rating**	**Weighted**	**Rating**	**Weighted**	**Rating**	**Weighted**	**Rating**	**Weighted**
Cost	5	3	15	4	20	3	15	3	15
Time	4	4	16	3	12	3	12	3	12
Value to Customer	4	2	8	4	16	5	20	3	12
Environmental Impact	5	2	10	5	25	5	25	5	25
Health and Safety	4	3	12	3	12	2	8	2	8
Risks	3	1	3	2	6	2	6	2	6
Social Impact	2	4	8	2	4	2	4	1	2
Total Value		19	**72**	23	**95**	22	**90**	19	**80**

Table 2. Weighted Selection Criteria

2.3 Selection Rationale

Option 1 and 4 were scored lowest as Coca-Cola has failed to meet some sustainability targets: they did not reduce virgin plastic obtained from non-renewable sources by 3 million metric tons between 2020 and 2025 (Coca-Cola, 2023). Furthermore, diversifying the workforce and promoting diversity was not deemed to be their most urgent sustainability issue to tackle, and Coca-Cola has displayed efforts to equalize gender representation, increasing their percentage of women in STEM roles to 56.4% in 2023 (Coca-ColaHBC, 2023).

Option 3 is very high in cost, but Coca-Cola has already successfully switched to 100% renewable energy in Europe and New Zealand (EuroPacific, 2024). Limitations are indirect, they arise due to their large global presence, making it harder to use advanced technologies in developing and emerging markets.

Option 2 scored highest on the selection criteria: Coca-Cola's most urgent issue is related to their carbon footprint. This is not only affecting their company reputation but is also contributing to Earth's climate change, widening the scale of the problem. **Option 2** was therefore chosen.

Section 3: Suggested Project

3.1 Project Outline

To help tackle Coca-Cola's weaknesses, ReCon suggests incorporating a generative AI to help design environmentally efficient packaging. This is done in 5 phases.

1. **Concept: Assess project viability for Coca-Cola's sustainable strategy**

Identify sustainability challenges, define high-level objectives and goals, engage key stakeholders to gather requirements and support, estimate costs, assess expected benefits.

2. **Definition: Refine the project scope and establish a detailed plan**

Develop detailed project plans, timeline, resources and milestones. Conduct risk and regulatory compliance assessments. Collect data on current packaging materials and their environmental impact. Create partnerships with suppliers.

3. **Deployment: Develop the GPT**
   - Part 1: Gather and prepare (structure, annotate, and validate) sustainability data provided by Coca-Cola.
   - Part 2: Fine-tune and optimize the model. Assess GPT output designs' achievability. Test biodegradable packaging in selected regions.
   - Part 3: Collect feedback, adjust and improve model. Develop workshops for ethical labor practices.

4. **Transition: Deliver outputs to stakeholders and finalize the project**

Implement GPT into supply chain, provide GPT user training workshops, discuss results to stakeholders, review benefits report and provide closure documentation.

5. **Adoption and Benefits: Ensure project benefits are achieved and used**

Track key metrics (plastic waste reduction, supplier compliance), monitor consumer satisfaction and transparency improvements, review progress semi-annually, adjust strategies based on GPT performance and stakeholder feedback

3.2 Success Criteria

Below are the success criteria for the GPT model and measurable examples of what it must achieve. These criteria directly reflect the project's objectives of promoting sustainable product design, integrating circular economy principles and improving customer engagement, ensuring alignment with Coca-Cola's broader sustainability goals.

- **Sustainable product design**: Recommends beverage packaging materials with demonstratable reduction in environmental impact (e.g. a 10% lower carbon footprint).
- **Equitable Labour Practices**: Suggests equity and ethical standards in supply chain.
- **Circular Economy Integration**: Suggests design modifications that enable Coca-Cola materials to be fully disassembled (e.g. integrating recycled materials into at least 80% of all new packaging).
- **Customer Engagement and Transparency**: Ensures non-bias reports related to current environmental and social impact of Coca-Cola products with at least 95% accuracy and transparency are shared. Suggests strategies/campaigns to increase customer engagement.
- **Innovation**: Speeds up the process of developing new, eco-friendly packaging, at a high frequency (e.g. quarterly).
- **Financial and Environmental Benefits**: Suggests lower production costs, more efficient operations (e.g. lower the company's carbon footprint by 20% and waste generation by 25%).

Adhering to these success criteria mitigates the chances of failure by addressing risks across the iron triangle (Villanova, 2024): ensuring **time**-bound deliverables to meet Coca-Cola's 2030 goals (*Section 5*), maintaining **cost** efficiency through optimized operations (*Section 4*), and aligning the project **scope** with clearly defined sustainability objectives (*Executive Summary*), all while maintaining beverage quality and consumer satisfaction.

3.3 Project Benefits

If successful, the project would have several benefits to multiple stakeholders. These are summarized in Figure 2 below.

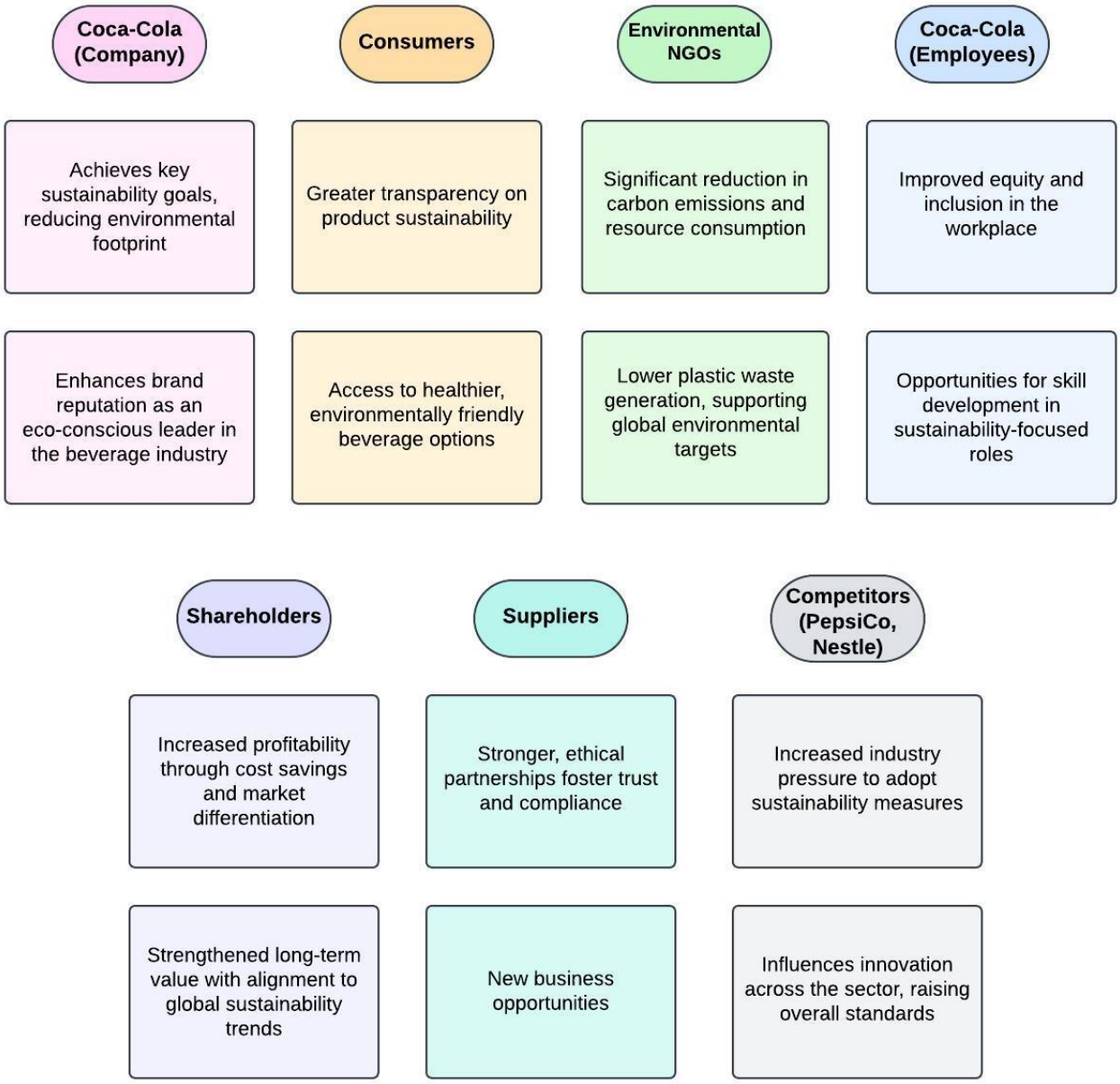

Figure 2. Project Benefits Description

3.4 APM Method Implementation

The APM method will be applied to this project using an Extended Life Cycle (Murray-Webster, 2019), as it suits situations where requirements and implementation methods are well-understood. Building on ReCon's experience with Nike's GPT project, the need for iterative refinement has diminished, enabling a structured, step-by-step approach focused on implementation and benefits realization. This method has more emphasis on people and behaviors, and on deployment and the transition from project to operations. This approach supports Coca-Cola's urgent packaging goals – 100% recyclable packaging by 2025 – by emphasizing swift deployment over prolonged iterations.

Unlike Nike's hybrid approach, with experimentation and refinement, the Extended Life Cycle enables faster implementation, leveraging ReCon's expertise while ensuring alignment with sustainability strategies. Stakeholder engagement will be prioritized early to secure alignment, while risk management and long-term benefits monitoring will ensure measurable improvements in reducing carbon footprints and improving ethical supply chain practices.

3.5 Risks and Challenges

While implementing this project, ReCon must highlight certain risks and challenges that may arise.

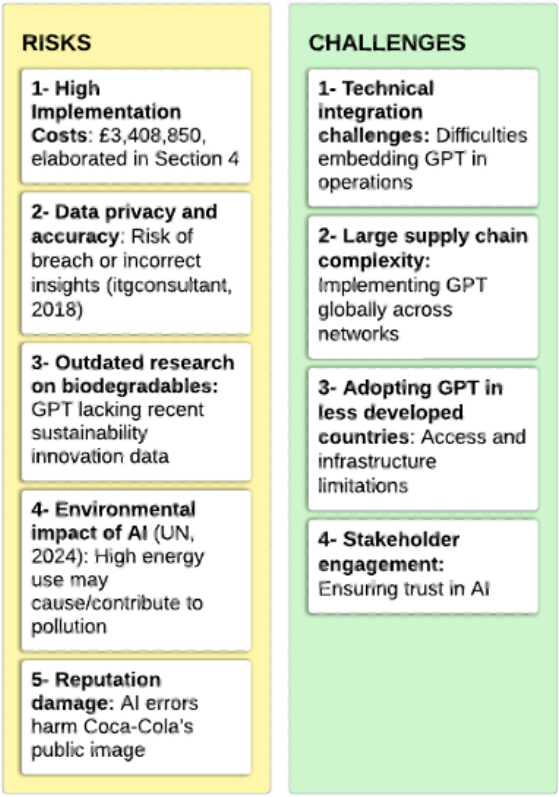

Figure 3. Risks and Challenges

Assessing risks and challenges using a a Probability/Impact matrix, where “R” = Risk and “C” = Challenge, numbered according to Figure 3.

		Impact				
		Very Low	Low	Medium	High	Very High
Probability	Very Low					
	Low			C4	R2	
	Medium			R5	R3	
	High			C1, C2	R1, C3	
	Very high					R4

Table 2. Risks and Challenges evaluated on P/I Matrix

Risk 4 (R4) is deemed to have the highest impact and highest probability: this approach risks creating a paradox where efforts to mitigate pollution through AI end up causing environmental harm due to the energy demands of its implementation. To mitigate this challenge, Coca-Cola must ensure the energy used to supply the GPT is 100% renewable.

Section 4: Commercial

4.1 Contractual and Funding Arrangements

i. **Contract:** Licensing Agreement, 2 years, starting December 13, 2024
ii. **ReCon service**: Custom GPT for Sustainable Design
iii. **Payments**:
    a. Total Cost: £3,408,850 (detailed in Section 4.2)
    b. 20% upfront payment (£681,770)
    c. Remainder to be paid in 3 installments.
iv. **Obligations of Coca-Cola**:
    a. Fund the R&D for latest eco-friendly materials
    b. Fund manufacturing amenities (e.g. renewable energy sources)
    c. Provide ReCon with 100% transparent and accurate data on current designs, environmental impact, and workforce distribution
v. **Termination of contract**: Not permitted

4.2 High-level Costs

The project's cost breakdown structure is described in table 3. Months and salary estimations were done using the Nike-GPT project brief. Note "D" = Day.

People Costs				
Role	**No. of People**	**Rate/Month**	**No. of months**	**Total Cost**
Logistics Manager	1	£5,550	3	£16,650
Logistics Assistant	1	£3,950	3	£11,850
Accountant	1	£6,550	6	£39,300
Computer systems technicians	1	£4,450	5	£22,250
Technical Project Director	1	*£2,250/D* = £67,500	5	£337,500
Project Manager	1	*£1,850/D* = £55,500	10	£555,000
Data Science Engineer	2	*£1,650/D* = £49,500	6	£594,000
Data Scientist	2	*£1,400/D* = £42,000	6	£504,000
Natural Language Processing Engineer	1	£1,600/D = £48,000	3	£144,000
UX/UI Designer	1	£1,350/D = £40,500	3	£121,500
Sustainability Analyst	2	£1,750/D = £52,500	6	£630,000
Support Engineer	2	£1,200/D = £36,000	3	£216,000
			Total:	**£3,192,050**

Table 3. High Level Costs

Assuming part of ReCon's team (i.e. 16 people) will have to travel to Coca-Cola's headquarters in Atlanta, Georgia, USA, for 3 weeks during Phase 3.

Additional Costs		
Service	**Cost/person**	**Total Cost (16 people, 3 weeks)**
Flights (British Airways)	£740 round-trip	£11,840 (one-time)
Hotel (Booking.com, 2024)	£150/night	£50,400
Transportation	£80/D	£26,880
Food and beverages	£380/D	£127,680
	Total:	**£216,800**

Table 4. Additional Costs

Thus, the total cost of the project is estimated to be **£3,408,850**. These costs abide by the contractual agreements described in section 4.1.

Section 5: Timescales

1.1 High-Level Project Delivery

Table 5 below describes the timescale required to complete every phase of the project and its key activities described in Section 3.1.

No.	Phase	Duration (weeks)
1	**Concept**	7
2	**Definition**	10
3	**Deployment** *(ReCon team flies to USA)* - Part 1: Gather and prepare data - Part 2: Fine-tuning and optimization - Part 3: Collect feedback and conduct workshops	 4 4 4 (12)
4	**Transition**	4
5	**Adoption and Benefits Realization** → First review 8 weeks after project completion, then bi-annually for the 2 following years	8

Table 5. High-Level Timeline

Durations were estimated by comparing the phases to the previous Nike-GPT project plan, thus excluding weekends and public holidays in the USA (timeanddate, 2024) and UK (GOV.UK, 2024). The project is shorter assuming the ReCon team now has further experience in such projects.

Figure 4 below is a High-Level Gantt Chart showing that the project is estimated to last a total of 41 weeks, starting on December 13, 2024, and ending January 16, 2026.

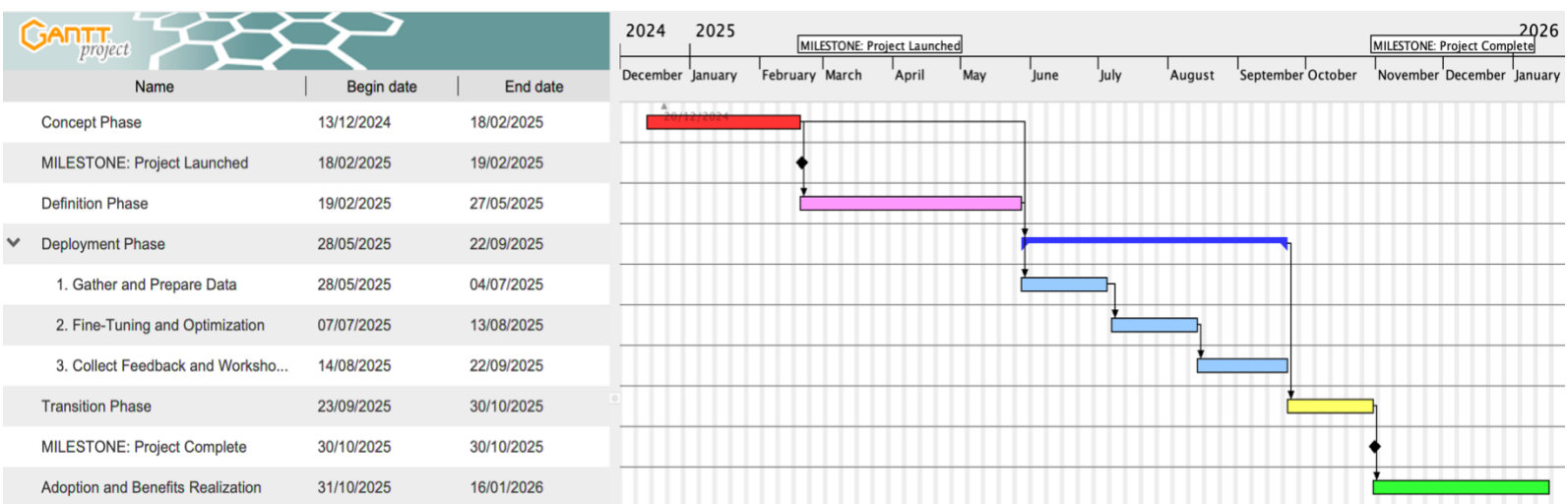

Figure 4. High-Level Gantt Chart

1.1 Benefits Realization

The benefits realization will be checked in the first 2 months, then twice a year for 2 years after project closure. The long-term benefits of the project deliver environmental value, allowing Coca-Cola to reduce their carbon emissions, social value by improving labor practices and supplier compliances, and customer value by ensuring transparent information and innovative designs.

In alignment with the **Green Book** principles (Gov.UK, 2022), the benefits realization process will account for risks and uncertainties, ensuring adjustments are made as needed to maximize the project's long-term value and alignment with strategic objectives. Coca-Cola can expect revenue seeing that recycled materials tend to cost less than virgin plastics (Vishnuvajhala, 2024). The exact financial impact would depend on the manufacturing costs of the new eco-friendly packaging materials and designs.

Conclusions and Implications

In conclusion, this business case outlines the opportunity for Coca-Cola to transform its business into a regenerative, circular and distributive system using AI. By following a structured Extended Life Cycle approach, Coca-Cola can aim to achieve its key objectives, such as sustainable design, equitable labor practices, circular economy integration, enhanced customer engagement and measurable financial and environmental benefits. Following the option appraisal, option 2 (transition to fully recyclable/biodegradable packaging) was chosen to be established, with the project expecting to last 41 weeks and cost £3,408,850.

In terms of medium-to-long term implications, implementing this approach will enable Coca-Cola to reduce waste, lower its carbon footprint and enhance its brand reputation as a leader in the beverage industry. Furthermore, improved transparency, innovation and ethical practices will deepen customer loyalty, attract socially conscious consumers and strengthen stakeholder relationships. By integrating AI-driven suitability into its core operations, Coca-Cola will not only meet its immediate sustainability goals but also position itself as a global leader in sustainable business practices.

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